

implemented. There is no ANC on the headphones, which at ₹20,000 is something that many would expect a pair of headphones to have. But these are not like other headphones. These stand out. What makes them stand out is the lack of features. But, what they lose out here, they make up in other aspects like build quality, comfort, and performance which we will talk about next.

PERFORMANCE

In terms of performance, it is business as usual for the ATH-M50xBT2. The sound signature isn't completely flat, as it is the case with many other studio grade headphones out there. There is colouration in the mids and highs, which might disappoint the purists who would ideally want a flat sound. But for the audience which these headphones are targeted at, the sound signature is well rounded.

The bass has been neutered, so bass heads will need to tune the sound signature in the app. In the mids and the highs, there is a significant boost, which can be seen in the graph below. As a result, the sound is bright, and perfect for mixing tracks where you will get a fair idea of the vocals and instruments especially metal instruments. But too much of a boost is also something that is not good. It introduces sibilance, which is the over amplification of 'S' and 'T' sounds, and causes fatiguing when you are listening to the headphones for longer periods of time.

The ATH-M50xBT had significantly more boost in the highs than these headphones, which caused them to have sibilance in the audio.

With the volume cranked up to max, there was barely any distortion that I experienced. Enough about the sound signature. Let's move on to the microphone performance of the headphones.

The ATH-M50xBT2 come with two microphones fitted on the left earcup. This microphone arrangement seemed weird to me to begin with, and when I started using the headphones, the lacklustre performance of the mic came through. While it held its own in quiet

environments, as soon as there was background noise, like people talking about 5-6 feet away from where I was, the pickup quality of the microphones took a plunge. So, if you were planning to take calls on these headphones during your commute, then be ready to answer all the 'Huh?' and 'What did you say?' that come your way.

As mentioned earlier, there is no ANC on the headphones. So, to cut out background noise you will be relying on the passive isolation and fit of the headphones. These headphones fit me well so the passive isolation was sufficient in most cases in office. There was minimal sound leakage as well, until I hit the 70 percent volume mark. Over that, my colleagues could hear every song that I was listening to.

The Bluetooth connectivity on these headphones is solid. I had two wooden walls between me and the source and the connection was strong! As for the CODEC support, these headphones support both LDAC and AAC, which would appeal to the people who are planning to connect to these headphones primarily using Bluetooth.

BATTERY LIFE

The claimed battery life of these headphones is about 50 hours on a single charge. When I tested the battery life of these headphones, the headphones came close to the claimed figure. The ATH-M50xBT2 lasted for 46 hours and 58 minutes at 50 per cent volume which is pretty impressive. But keep in mind that these headphones do not have ANC on them, which generally tends to bring the battery life down of most other headphones significantly.

When you need to charge these headphones, you can connect the included USB-C cable. If the claims made by Audio Technica are anything to by, then these headphones will get up to 3 hours of use on a 10-minute rapid charge.

VERDICT

Now, the main question – Are they a worthy successor to their predecessor the ATH-M50xBT? And, are they worth spending the extra ₹10,000 over the

ATH-M20xBT? The short answer is YES and yes!

The ATH-M50xBT2 bring a host of upgrades over the ATH-M50xBT making for a well rounded pair of headphones which some might even pick over some of the mainstream options out there. The sound signature is well rounded and suited for both regular listening and studio work. The battery life is impressive. There is added support for low-latency mode, Google Fast Pair, a dedicated app which you can use for customisation, and voice assistant. There is no ANC or touch/capacitive controls which many headphones in the mainstream have. But, if you are going for these, you will have to give up on those features in favour of great sound!

As for the extra money that you'd be shelling out over the ATH-M20xBT, it depends on your needs. If you have the budget, then the upgrades that you get on ATH-M50xBT2 over the ATH-M20xBT is definitely worth the money. But, don't push your financial boundaries if you are someone on a tight budget. The ATH-M20xBT are a good starting point as well.

If you are looking to use these daily, then I'd say go for the mainstream offerings from brands like Sony and Sennheiser. They have all the creature comfort that you'd come to expect from a pair of headphones priced at ₹20,000. As for other options similar to the ATH-M50xBT2, the one that stands out is the V-MODA - Crossfade 2 Wireless Codex Edition. At the time of writing, it was retailing for the exact same price as the ATH-M50xBT2.

–Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Type: Closed-back dynamic | Driver Diameter: 45 mm | Frequency Response: 15 - 28,000 Hz | Sensitivity: 99 dB/mW | Impedance: 38 ohms | Battery: DC 3.7V lithium polymer battery | Weight Approx.: 307g | Charging Time Approx.: 3.5 hours | Microphone Type: MEMS type | Microphone Sensitivity: -38 dB (1V/Pa at 1 kHz) | Microphone Frequency Response: 85 -15,000 Hz | Microphone Polar Pattern: Omnidirectional

CONTACT

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